

Hegel's dialectic

Having described reality as a historical process (see [Reality is a historical process](#)), Hegel then pursued the idea that not only is the Spirit that comprises reality constantly evolving, but also this process has an underlying structure. He explained this in terms of a dialectical progression: every notion, he maintained, contains within itself a contradictory notion, and the antagonism between the two opposing notions is resolved by the emergence of a new notion. The first notion he called the 'thesis', its contradiction the 'antithesis' and the resulting new notion the 'synthesis'. Within a thesis such as the notion of a tyrannical regime, for example, the notion of freedom from tyranny is present as an antithesis. The resolution of these opposing notions, the synthesis, would be the notion of justice through the rule of law. The synthesis is richer in meaning than the thesis from which it is derived, implying not only a historical progression of events, but also a process that allows the Spirit (including our own thought and consciousness) to achieve a better, truer understanding of itself.

